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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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CHAPTER IX GRANDPARENTS AND GRANDCHILDREN

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WE have mentioned earlier that the relations of grandparents and grandchildren can be regarded as a foil to those of parents and children. Tallensi themselves often draw the contrast. It is particularly striking with the paternal grandparents. For in a three-generation joint family the head is a grandfather and the senior *dugdaana* a grandmother. As head of the family the grandfather holds jural, economic, and ritual authority over all its members, including those whom he calls grandchildren, and there is a contrast between his authority and his familiarity in personal relations with his grandchildren. It reflects the contrast between the cleavage due to difference of status and role in terms of the lineage principle and the ties of cognatic kinship between grandchildren and paternal grandparents. This contrast does not occur with the maternal grandparents, in whose relations with a daughter's child the question of authority does not arise. When Tallensi say that a person can die happily if he or she has 'reached grandchildren (*paa yaas*)' they refer primarily to paternal grandparent and grandchild.

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A grandchild of either sex refers to a grandfather of either line as *ba-kpeem*, literally 'older father', or more formally as *yaab*, and to a grandmother of either line as *ma-kpeem*, literally 'older mother', or more formally as *yaab-p(ɔ)k*. Grandparents are addressed by personal name or, in the case of grandmothers, by the clan name used for them by their affines. A grandchild is described as *yaan* by any of its grandparents and addressed by his or her own name.

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The essential feature of the relationship between grandchild and grandparent is that they can tease and joke with each other and each other's spouses. As we have seen, between parent and child this would be almost equal to sacrilege. A grandchild can tweak his grandparent's ear—hence the diviner's sign for grandparent, pointing to the ear—or pretend to mock him or her as 'an old baggage (*bonk(ɔ)r(ə)ga*)' or play practical jokes on them such as snatching at their food. Grandparents, reciprocally, tease their grandchildren, calling them 'you ugly thing (*bonl(ɔ)r(ə)ga*)', or by similar epithets that would be insults in another genealogical context. This joking relationship holds for both sets of grandparents, and serves the purpose of reconciling the potentially conflicting elements in their relationships.¹

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With it goes an intimacy and mutual trust, more particularly between  237 patrilineal grandparent and grandchild of the same sex, such as is not found between any other kinsfolk, close or distant. Its nearest parallel is the relationship of full siblings. And as a grandchild grows older this aspect of its relations with its grandparent becomes stronger. Nothing delights grandparents so much as to take care of their grandchildren in babyhood or early childhood. Children often sleep with a grandparent, as we have noted. A woman whose father- or mother-in-law is alive always has someone with whom to leave her baby. Joking is one of the ways in which the grandparent shows his or her joy in the child. But as the grandchild grows older and begins to associate on more adult terms with its grandparents, these demonstrations of affection become unnecessary. Occasionally, as mood and situation dictate, a grandfather or grandmother will throw out a jest at a grandchild. Thus I once heard an old man call out to his grandson's wife with a laugh, as she sauntered past, that she ought to get a wider back *voog* (the decorated flap worn by women over the intergluteal fold) as the one she was wearing was immodest. But it is more likely to be the grandchild who occasionally throws a jest at the grandparent.

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¹ Cf. the similar usage between siblings-in-law, p. 120. Joking in the present case reconciles the familiarity permissible on the grounds of personal interest and the social equivalence of alternate generations, with the respect due to grandparents because of their age and their lineage status.

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